



ARYNA'S HIGH-PERCENTAGE POWER TENNIS REPEATEDLY ELICITED ERRORS FROM ZHENG, PARTICULARLY HIGH-BOUNCING, WIDE SERVES

Beatrice Haddad-Maia 7-6 (7), 6-3.

In the most dramatic first-week upset, Anna Blinkova, yet another Russian, outlasted No. 3 seed and 2022 Wimbledon champion Elena Rybakina 6-4, 4-6, 7-6 (20). The fluctuating tiebreaker — in which Blinkova fended off six match points before prevailing on her 10th match point — prompted *ESPN* analyst Pam Shriver to say, “You don’t see 16 match points, maybe once in a lifetime.”

After the longest singles match tiebreaker in men’s or women’s tennis history, Blinkova wrote, “Never give up” on the courtside camera. Then she went down on her knees and cried.

The carnage opened up the draw for the highest seed left, No. 12 Zheng Qinwen. Despite not facing a

top-50 opponent en route to the final, the 21-year-old Chinese dropped three sets, the toughest battle coming against Wang Yafan,

her 94th-ranked compatriot, 6-4, 2-6, 7-6 (8). Conversely, Dayana Yastremska, Zheng’s semifinal opponent, knocked out three seeds — No. 7 and reigning Wimbledon champion Marketa Vondrousova 6-1, 6-2, No. 27 Emma Navarro 6-2, 2-6, 6-1, and No. 18, two-time AO champion Victoria Azarenka 7-6 (6), 6-4. Thus, she became the first qualifier to advance to the AO semis since 1976.

But nine matches had taken a mental and physical toll on the hard-hitting, but inconsistent Ukrainian. Zheng finally ended Yastremska’s Cinderella story 6-4, 6-4 with 33 winners and 11 aces.

In the final, both the players indulged in ‘first-strike’ power tennis, though Sabalenka did it better as Zheng found out when Sabalenka whipped her 6-1, 6-4 in the 2023 US Open quarterfinals, winning 16 of the first 19 points. With a potent serve that smacked a tournament-high 48 aces, a strong forehand, and superior court coverage that can turn defense into offense, Zheng had a puncher’s chance.

That small chance never materialised as a supremely confident Sabalenka, much like at the US Open four months earlier, streaked to a 3-0 lead. Zheng’s best chance for a service break came when she led 0-40 on Sabalenka serve in the third game. But the Chinese lost her nerve and played tentatively, allowing Sabalenka to seize five straight points, highlighted by a backhand winner at 30-40. The

Belarussian took the opening set 6-3. No longer could opponents count on double faults, once her *bete noire*. Sabalenka committed just 10 in her first six matches, and she was even stingier in the final with none.

Instead, it was Zheng who double faulted three times to start the second set, the last on break point to give Sabalenka, a great frontrunner, a 1-0 lead. Aryna produced the most dazzling shot of the match at 30-all when she returned a second serve with power, spin, and accuracy for a severely angled crosscourt winner.

Zheng fought gamely with positive body language despite the match slipping away. When she overhit a forehand serve return to increase Sabalenka’s advantage to 3-1, the crowd moaned.

Throughout the final, the Belarussian’s high-percentage power tennis repeatedly elicited errors from Zheng, particularly high-bouncing, wide serves.

With new balls, the wind at her back, and a 5-2 lead, Sabalenka served for her second Grand Slam title. Could Zheng somehow stop her foe’s seemingly irresistible offense?

The Chinese stepped up her aggression and had a break point at 30-40. Sabalenka squelched that with a 116-mph ace, coaxed a forehand error, and finished it off with a forehand crosscourt winner.

In a low-key victory celebration, she raised her arms and blew kisses to the cheering crowd. Then she scurried to hug her team, tapping her easy-going fitness trainer Jason Stacy on his bald head. It was all good fun as Sabalenka slapped and autographed the bald dome before matches and even stretched her legs by kicking objects off it.

During her speech to the crowd, she evoked memories of Li Na’s funny remarks about her husband Dennis when she thanked her team and then wisecracked, “Without me, you wouldn’t be as good as well.”

Summing up Aryna’s 6-3, 6-2 masterclass, Mary Joe Fernandez said, “There are no holes in Sabalenka’s game. This is as dominant a performance as you’ll see in a Grand Slam final.”